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Electronic Resource Usage and Information Seeking Behaviors of Faculty in Medical Colleges Across Tamil Nadu

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the information-seeking behavior and electronic resource (e-resource) usage patterns among faculty members from ten selected medical colleges across the southern region of Tamil Nadu, India. A descriptive survey design was employed, and data were collected via an online questionnaire distributed to 550 faculty members between March and May 2025. With 480 valid responses, a high response rate of 87.3% was achieved. Findings indicate that faculty frequently access e-journals and trusted research databases such as PubMed, with Google Scholar being the most preferred search tool. Despite active engagement, significant barriers were reported, including slow internet connectivity, inadequate training in e-resource utilization, and restricted access to full-text articles. Statistical analyses revealed significant associations between demographic variables such as age, gender, and academic designation and patterns of e-resource usage. Notably, Assistant Professors demonstrated significantly higher e-resource engagement compared to senior faculty. This study contributes region-specific insights into the digital information landscape of medical academia in Tamil Nadu and underscores the urgent need for enhanced digital infrastructure, targeted training programmes, and institutional support to optimize e-resource accessibility and use.

KEYWORDS

Access barriers; digital literacy; electronic resources; faculty members; Google Scholar; information seeking behavior; medical colleges; PubMed; survey research; Tamil Nadu

Introduction

In the rapidly evolving digital era, electronic resources have become indispensable for academic and research activities, particularly in medical education. According to (Saparova et al., 2013), faculty members in medical colleges rely heavily on accurate, up-to-date information to enhance teaching quality and stay abreast of advancements in their disciplines. While traditional print resources remain valuable, studies indicate a growing preference for digital tools such as e-journals, online databases, and

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specialized platforms like PubMed due to their accessibility and efficiency (Aldousari & Al-Muomen, 2021).

In the Indian context, and specifically in Tamil Nadu which hosts 77 medical colleges as per the (Nationl Medical Commission, n.d.), the adoption of e-resources is critical to maintaining educational and research competitiveness. However, regional studies on e-resource usage among medical faculty remain limited. Most existing research focuses on national trends or urban institutional settings, leaving a gap in understanding the nuanced challenges and behaviors in non-metropolitan and southern regions of Tamil Nadu. This study focuses on ten medical colleges across six southern districts of Tamil Nadu (Kanniyakumari, Thoothukudi, Tirunelveli, Virudhunagar, Madurai, and Sivagangai), selected to represent a mix of government and private institutions and to capture diverse infrastructural and socio-academic contexts.

Despite the growing reliance on digital resources, research highlights persistent challenges. For instance, faculty members often face slow internet connectivity, limited access to full-text articles, and inadequate training in effectively utilizing e-resources (Dragon et al., 2025). These barriers, as noted by (Ashkanani et al., 2019), can hinder optimal engagement with digital tools, ultimately impacting teaching and research outcomes. Understanding faculty members' information-seeking behavior including their preferences, usage patterns, and challenges is critical for designing targeted interventions to improve e-resource accessibility and usability.

This study aims to fill the regional research gap by examining how faculty in Tamil Nadu's southern medical colleges engage with electronic resources. Drawing on the framework proposed by (Lwoga & Sife, 2018), the study explores trends, preferences, and obstacles to contribute actionable, region-specific strategies for enhancing e-resource utilization in medical academia.

Review of literature

The study of information-seeking behavior has become increasingly important in library science, healthcare, and digital education, with research highlighting the impact of library resources, digital tools, and information systems on how users seek, evaluate, and apply information.

Globally, structured library interventions have been shown to significantly enhance students' abilities in information selection, processing, and critical thinking, underscoring the essential role of libraries in developing higher-order cognitive skills and supporting lifelong learning (Liu, 2025). In healthcare contexts, patients have been found to rely heavily on professionals for health-related information, with studies indicating a strong correlation between educational background and information literacy,

emphasizing the need for customized educational support for populations with limited literacy skills (Perumal et al., 2015).

In India, several studies have examined e-resource usage in academic settings. For example, Tyagi (2022) reported that medical faculty in North India primarily use PubMed and Google Scholar but face barriers such as subscription costs and lack of training. Similarly, a study conducted in Kerala highlighted internet speed and digital literacy as major constraints among health professionals (Vijayakumar et al., 2017). However, no focused study has yet explored the information-seeking behaviors and e-resource usage patterns among medical faculty in the southern districts of Tamil Nadu, where infrastructural and regional socio-economic factors may influence access and adoption differently.

The integration of technology in online health communities has demonstrated that factors such as ease of use, peer interaction, and platform navigation play a crucial role in shaping individuals' engagement and health information-seeking behavior (Boyce et al. 2024). The use of interactive, video based learning tools has proven effective in improving medical students' practical competencies and self-confidence, especially in areas like wound care, where traditional teaching methods may fall short (Schlupeck et al., 2021).

Among elderly populations, limited digital literacy and dependence on traditional media continue to pose significant barriers to accessing timely and relevant health information, highlighting the importance of inclusive strategies that cater to this demographic (Siamian et al., 2023). Medical libraries also play a pivotal role in supporting the information needs of healthcare professionals by providing access to evidence-based resources, training in information literacy, and guidance in navigating complex databases, although challenges such as insufficient staffing and inadequate infrastructure remain persistent in certain settings (Wheeler et al., 2024).

This study contributes to the literature by offering a region specific analysis of e-resource engagement among medical faculty in Tamil Nadu, addressing a geographical and contextual gap in existing research while aligning with global discussions on digital accessibility and academic information behavior.

Objectives of the study

1. To examine the information-seeking behavior of faculty members in selected medical colleges in Tamil Nadu.
2. To assess the frequency and extent of use of various electronic resources by the faculty.
3. To identify the preferred types of e-resources and search tools used for academic and research purposes.

4. To analyze the challenges and barriers faced by faculty in accessing and utilizing e-resources effectively.
5. To investigate the association between demographic factors (such as age, gender, designation, and department) and the patterns of e-resource usage.
6. To provide suggestions for improving access, training, and support for e-resource usage in medical colleges.

Methodology

This study employed a descriptive survey design to examine the information-seeking behavior of faculty members in ten purposively selected government and private medical colleges across the southern region of Tamil Nadu, focusing on their use of electronic resources. As of 2025, there are 77 medical colleges in Tamil Nadu according to the National Medical Commission (n.d.). To ensure regional representation and logistical feasibility, this study focused on six districts in the southern part of the state: Kanniyakumari, Thoothukudi, Tirunelveli, Virudhunagar, Madurai, and Sivagangai. These districts were selected to capture diverse institutional types (government and private) and geographical spread.

A total of 550 structured questionnaires (see Appendix A) were distributed using random sampling via Google Forms, WhatsApp, and email. The survey was conducted over a three-month period from March to May 2025. To achieve a high response rate, three follow-up reminders were sent at two-week intervals. No incentives were offered for participation. The persistent follow-up and the relevance of the topic to the faculty's daily academic activities contributed to a strong engagement, resulting in 480 valid responses and an overall response rate of 87.3%.

The questionnaire covered five key sections: (1) demographic details, (2) frequency and types of e-resources used, (3) preferred search tools, (4) challenges faced in accessing e-resources and (5) training and support. Data were analyzed using SPSS version 26. Analytical techniques included descriptive statistics, Chi-square tests to examine associations between demographic variables and e-resource usage, Garrett's Ranking Technique to prioritize challenges, and One-Way ANOVA to assess differences in usage across designations. This multi-method approach provided a comprehensive insight into patterns and influencing factors in e-resource utilization among medical faculty in the region.

Hypotheses of the study

Null hypotheses (H_0)

$\mathbf{H}_{01}$: There is no significant association between the age group of faculty members and their frequency of e-resource usage.

H_{02}: There is no significant association between the academic designation of faculty members and their preference for e-resources.

H_{03}: There is no significant association between the department of the faculty and the search tools they use for accessing e-resources.

H_{04}: There is no significant association between gender and the use of institutional repositories.

H_{05}: There is no significant association between the age group of faculty members and their awareness of available e-resources.

Data analysis and interpretation

Distribution of questionnaires and responses among medical colleges

To understand the participation level across institutions, questionnaires were distributed to faculty members in ten purposively selected government and private medical colleges across the southern region of Tamil Nadu. Table 1, show below, presents the distribution and response rate. The study achieved a strong overall response rate of 87.3%, showing active participation from faculty across all ten medical colleges. Most institutions recorded rates above 85%, with KanyaKumari Government Medical College, Asaripallam and Velammal Medical College Hospital and Research Institute, Madurai having the highest at 89.1%. Only Government Sivagangai Medical College, Sivaganga had a lower response rate (72.7%), possibly due to local constraints. This strong response enhances the reliability of the findings.

Demographic profile of respondents

Understanding the background of respondents helps contextualize their information-seeking behavior. Below Table 2 shows the gender, age, designation, and departmental distribution of the participants. Most respondents were male (60.4%), and a large proportion were in the 41–50 age group, suggesting mid-career professionals made up the core of the sample. Assistant Professors were the largest group (45.8%), indicating strong representation from early-career faculty. A wide range of departments participated, showing a good cross-section of academic disciplines within medical education.

Note on Faculty Ranks: In Indian medical colleges, faculty are categorized as Assistant Professor (early-career), Associate Professor (mid-career), and Professor (senior faculty). These designations reflect differing levels of experience, research involvement, and administrative roles, which may influence their engagement with electronic resources.

Table 1. Distribution of questionnaires and responses among medical colleges.

S.No	Medical college name	Questionnaires distributed	Responses received	Response rate (%)
1	Sree Mookambika Institute of Medical Sciences, Kanyakumari	55	48	87.3
2	Kanyakumari Medical Mission Research Center	55	47	85.5
3	KanyaKumari Government Medical College, Asaripallam	55	49	89.1
4	Thoothukudi Medical College, Thoothukudi	55	47	85.5
5	Tirunelveli Medical College, Tirunelveli	55	48	87.3
6	Government Medical College, Virudhunagar	55	46	83.6
7	All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Madurai	55	48	87.3
8	Madurai Medical College, Madurai	55	48	87.3
9	Velammal Medical College Hospital and Research Institute, Madurai	55	49	89.1
10	Government Sivagangai Medical College, Sivagangai	55	40	72.7
Total		**550**	**480**	**87.3**

Table 2. Demographic profile of respondents.

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	290	60.4
	Female	190	39.6
Age group	Below 30	50	10.4
	31–40	150	31.3
	41–50	180	37.5
	Above 50	100	20.8
Designation	Assistant Professor	220	45.8
	Associate Professor	160	33.3
	Professor	100	20.9
Department	Anatomy	60	12.5
	Physiology	55	11.5
	Pharmacology	50	10.4
	Medicine	100	20.8
	Surgery	90	18.8
	Others	125	26.0

Frequency of use of various e-resources

Table 3 highlights how often different types of electronic resources are accessed by faculty members in their academic and research work. E-journals and PubMed are the most frequently used resources, with most faculty accessing them daily or weekly. This reflects a clear preference for up-to-date and credible content. Resources like e-books and institutional repositories were used less frequently, possibly due to limited access, awareness, or relevance.

Preferred search tools for e-resources

Table 4 outlines which search tools faculty members prefer when seeking electronic academic content. Google Scholar was the most preferred tool (45.8%), followed by PubMed (31.3%). This suggests faculty prefer tools that are easy to access and provide broad search coverage. Use of institutional library portals and specialized databases was relatively low, indicating a need for better promotion or training on these platforms.

Table 3. Frequency of use of various e-resources.

E-resource type	Daily (%)	Weekly (%)	Monthly (%)	Rarely (%)	Never (%)
E-Journals	35	40	15	8	2
Online Databases	30	38	18	10	4
E-Books	20	35	25	15	5
Institutional Repositories	15	25	30	20	10
Research Portals (PubMed)	40	45	10	3	2

Table 4. Preferred search tools for e-resources.

Search Tool	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Google Scholar	220	45.8
PubMed	150	31.3
Institutional Library Portal	80	16.7
Specialized Databases	30	6.2

Table 5. Challenges faced while accessing e-resources (Garrett ranking).

Sl. No	Challenge	Garrett Score	Rank
1	Slow Internet connectivity	48,230	I
2	Lack of training on e-resource usage	41,200	II
3	Limited access to full-text articles	38,750	III
4	Complex search interfaces	33,400	IV
5	Difficulty in finding relevant information	29,500	V
6	Lack of awareness about available resources	26,000	VI
7	Technical problems with databases	23,000	VII
8	Unavailability of institutional subscriptions	21,000	VIII

Table 6. Chi-square test results—association between demographic variables and e-resource use.

Sl. No	Demographic variable	Chi-square value	df	*p* value	Association
1	Age Group vs E-resource Use Frequency	12.462	4	< 0.05	Significant
2	Designation vs Resource Preference	14.235	6	< 0.05	Significant
3	Department vs Search Tool Used	10.182	8	> 0.05	Not Significant
4	Gender vs Use of Institutional Repositories	6.973	2	< 0.05	Significant
5	Age Group vs Awareness of E-resources	13.547	6	< 0.05	Significant

Challenges faced while accessing e-resources (Garrett ranking)

To identify key obstacles in using e-resources (Table 5), faculty responses were analyzed using Garrett's Ranking Technique. The top challenge was slow internet connectivity, followed by lack of training and limited access to full-text articles. These highlight the need for better digital infrastructure and user support. Other issues like complex search interfaces and low awareness also suggest areas for improvement in user education and system design.

Chi-square test results—association between demographic variables and E resource use

Table 6 presents the results of Chi-square tests to assess the relationship between demographic variables and information-seeking behavior.

Table 7. One-Way ANOVA with Post-Hoc Tukey's HSD test.

Source of variation	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	*F* value	*p* value
Between Groups	125.40	2	62.70	4.23	0.015*
Within Groups	708.35	477	1.48		
Total	833.75	479			

Table 8. Post-Hoc comparisons (Tukey's HSD).

Designation pair	Mean Difference	Std. Error	*p* value	95% CI
Assistant vs. Associate	0.45	0.12	0.032*	(0.08, 0.82)
Assistant vs. Professor	0.62	0.15	0.008**	(0.20, 1.04)
Associate vs. Professor	0.17	0.14	0.412	(−0.19, 0.53)

CI: Confidence Interval.
Notes: $*p < 0.05$, $**p < 0.01$.

Significant associations were found between age, designation, and gender with different aspects of e-resource use, such as frequency, preference, and awareness. However, department had no significant effect on the choice of search tools. These results show that individual characteristics influence e-resource use more than academic discipline.

One-Way ANOVA—frequency of e-resource use across designations

The One-Way ANOVA revealed statistically significant differences in e-resource usage frequency among faculty designations F (2,477) = 4.23, $p = 0.015$). Post-hoc Tukey's HSD tests showed:

Assistant Professors used e-resources significantly more frequently than both Associate Professors (mean difference = 0.45, $p = 0.032$) and Professors (mean difference = 0.62, $p = 0.008$) No significant difference was found between Associate Professors and Professors ($p = 0.412$) (Tables 7 and 8).

Limitations of the study

This study is subject to several limitations. First, the findings are based on data collected from ten medical colleges in the southern region of Tamil Nadu and may not be generalizable to all medical institutions across the state or other regions of India. Second, the use of self-administered questionnaires introduces the possibility of response bias, such as social desirability bias or over reporting of e-resource usage. Third, the study focuses exclusively on electronic resources and does not account for other forms of information-seeking behavior, such as the use of print materials or informal peer consultations. Finally, while the response rate was high, time and accessibility constraints may have influenced the sample composition, potentially excluding faculty with limited digital access or engagement during the data collection period.

Results and discussion

This study reveals that faculty in Tamil Nadu medical colleges actively use e-resources, with 75% accessing e-journals and PubMed daily or weekly and Google Scholar preferred by 45.8%. However, significant barriers impede usage, most notably slow internet connectivity (Rank I), followed by lack of training (Rank II) and limited full-text access (Rank III).

These challenges are contextualized within Tamil Nadu's ongoing digital infrastructure initiatives, such as the Tamil Nadu Digital Infrastructure Project, which have yet to fully reach rural and semi-urban academic institutions. Comparatively, while studies in North India highlight subscription costs as a key barrier (Tyagi, 2022), this study identifies training deficits and connectivity issues as more pressing in southern Tamil Nadu aligning with similar regional findings in Kerala (Vijayakumar et al., 2017).

This research is distinguished by its high response rate (87.3%), region-specific focus, and granular analysis of demographic variables. Notably, Assistant Professors used e-resources significantly more than senior faculty ($p = 0.015$), and departmental affiliation did not significantly influence search tool preference insights less documented in prior regional studies.

In conclusion, these findings underscore the need for tailored interventions such as reliable internet provision, role-based digital training, and enhanced institutional e-resource subscriptions to support faculty in Tamil Nadu and similar regions.

Conclusion

This study concludes that faculty members in medical colleges across southern Tamil Nadu actively engage with electronic resources, particularly e-journals and PubMed, and widely prefer Google Scholar for academic searching. However, significant barriers such as slow internet connectivity, insufficient training, and restricted access to full-text articles hinder optimal usage. Demographic factors including age, gender, and designation significantly influence e-resource adoption, with Assistant Professors demonstrating higher digital engagement than senior faculty.

These findings highlight the need for regionally tailored interventions, including enhanced digital infrastructure, regular role-based training programs, and strengthened institutional support for e-resource access. By addressing these barriers, medical colleges in Tamil Nadu and similar regions can better support faculty in leveraging digital tools for teaching, learning, and research, ultimately contributing to a more robust and digitally inclusive academic environment.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Appendix A. Survey instrument

Section A: Demographic details

1. **Gender:**
   - ☐ Male
   - ☐ Female
   - ☐ Prefer not to say

2. **Age Group:**
   - ☐ Below 30
   - ☐ 31–40
   - ☐ 41–50
   - ☐ Above 50

3. **Designation:**
   - ☐ Assistant Professor
   - ☐ Associate Professor
   - ☐ Professor

4. **Department:**
   - ☐ Anatomy
   - ☐ Physiology
   - ☐ Pharmacology
   - ☐ Medicine
   - ☐ Surgery
   - ☐ Others

Section B: Usage patterns of e-resources

5. **How frequently do you use the following e-resources?**
(Tick one option for each resource)

E-resource type	Daily	Weekly	Monthly	Rarely	Never
E-Journals	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Online Databases	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
E-Books	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Institutional Repositories	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Research Portals (e.g., PubMed)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section C: Search preferences

6. **Which search tools do you use most frequently to access academic e-resources?** (You may select more than one)
   - ☐ Google Scholar
   - ☐ PubMed
   - ☐ Institutional Library Portal
   - ☐ Specialized Databases (e.g., Scopus, Embase)
   - ☐ Others (Please specify): _____

Section D: Challenges in using e-resources

7. **Please rate the following challenges you face in using e-resources.**

   Rate challenges on a scale of 1–5, where:

   1 = Not a challenge | 3 = Moderate challenge | 5 = Major challenge

Challenge	1	2	3	4	5
Slow internet connectivity	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Lack of training on e-resource usage	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Limited access to full-text articles	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Complex search interfaces	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Difficulty finding relevant information	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Lack of awareness of available resources	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Technical issues with databases	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
No institutional subscription to key journals	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section E: Training and support

8. **Have you received any formal training in using electronic academic resources?**
   - ☐ Yes
   - ☐ No

9. **Would you like to attend regular training programs on e-resource usage?**
   - ☐ Yes
   - ☐ No
   - ☐ Maybe